UNDERSTANDING THE CALORIC SURPLUS

What a caloric surplus is, how much you need, and why more isn't better.

If your goal is to build size and strength, "eat more" is technically correct advice, and almost useless on its own. Eat *how* much more? For how long? And why do some people bulk for months and end up looking noticeably more muscular, while others just end up... bigger? The answer starts with understanding what a caloric surplus actually is and what it can and can't do for you.

The One-Sentence Version

A caloric surplus means consistently giving your body more energy than it burns, and that extra energy is what gives your body the raw material and the green light to build new muscle tissue, on top of whatever training stimulus you're providing.

That's the whole mechanism. Training tells your body *which* tissue to build. The surplus gives it the energy and materials to actually build it. Skip either half and growth stalls, you can't out-train an energy deficit into muscle gain, and you can't out-eat a lack of training stimulus into it either.

Why You Need a Surplus At All

Building new muscle tissue costs energy, protein synthesis, the cellular machinery that turns training stimulus into bigger, stronger fibers, isn't free. When you're in a deficit or even right at maintenance, your body is under real pressure to conserve energy, and building new tissue is one of the first things it deprioritizes. A surplus removes that pressure. It's the difference between telling your body "we might not have enough to get through today" versus "we have room to invest in tomorrow."

This is also why "recomping", building muscle and losing fat at the exact same time, is realistic mainly for beginners, people returning after time off, or those with a meaningful amount of fat to lose. For an intermediate or advanced lifter who's already lean and trained, a deliberate surplus is usually what actually moves the needle on size.

Roughly How Much Surplus Is Needed

You don't need a dramatic surplus to grow. A useful starting range for most people is **roughly 10-20% above maintenance calories**, which for a lot of people lands somewhere around **200-500 extra calories a day**. That's enough to fuel real tissue growth without the surplus itself becoming the main event.

This is a starting point, not a prescription, your actual number depends on body size, training experience, and how your body responds over the first few weeks. (If you want the precise, coaching-level breakdown, including how to size your exact number and tell if it's too aggressive, that's covered in the premium tier of this series.)

Why More Isn't Better

The instinct to "eat big to get big" is understandable, but it misunderstands the mechanism. Muscle can only be built at a certain rate, your body has a ceiling on how much new tissue it can construct in a given week, regardless of how much extra food you provide above what that process actually requires. Calories beyond what growth can use don't get banked for later or converted into extra gains. They get stored as fat.

A bigger surplus doesn't mean bigger muscles, faster. It mostly means more fat gained per pound of muscle built, a worse ratio, not a better outcome. This is the exact idea the next piece in this series digs into: why the "dirty bulk" approach backfires, and what a smarter surplus actually looks like in practice.

What This Means for You

- A caloric surplus is fuel for growth, not the growth itself, training is still what tells your body what to build.
- A moderate surplus (roughly 10-20% above maintenance) is enough to drive real muscle gain for most people.
- Muscle building has a rate limit; calories beyond what that rate needs are stored as fat, not extra gains.
- Bigger is not better here, the goal is the smallest surplus that still produces consistent progress, not the largest one you can tolerate.

This article is educational and general in nature, not individualized medical or nutrition advice. If you have a medical condition or are taking medication, talk to your doctor before making significant changes to your diet or training volume.